CHAPTER 2 | **WALLS TURNED SIDEWAYS ARE BRIDGES**

Angela Davis, Cold War Berliners, and Imprisoned Freedom Struggles

In East Germany, the African American struggle for civil rights elicited an interest at least as strong as in the Federal Republic. The major difference to West Germany, however, was that the East German solidarity movement was engineered and enforced by the government. Ever since the regime's beginning, the fight against racism was deeply ingrained in East German ideology.
—MARIA HÖHN AND MARTIN KLIMKE

By 1965 the violent border clashes and tense diplomatic relations of the first years of the Berlin Wall had begun tempering into a sanctioned coexistence between East and West. That summer, Angela Davis, a young African American graduate student from Birmingham, Alabama, boarded a boat, en route to West Germany.

In the years following the Berlin Crisis, the two Germanys had negotiated some limited, temporary border crossings, and the two sides were moving toward steadier, if not stabilized, relations. Following the 1962 tragic shooting death of East German Peter Fechter, whose attempt to escape was captured by cameras and circulated in the Western press with painful and gruesome detail, reports of instances of violent skirmishes along the border diminished. Frederick Taylor writes, "The tunneling continued, but outside in the wider world things were changing. The crisis atmosphere that followed the building of the Wall slowly gave way to a kind of sullen acceptance."[1] The geopolitical reality in Berlin moved from crisis within a divided city to a sustained, cautious, parallel existence. In 1963 authorities agreed to permit West Berliners to visit their relatives in the East for the Christmas and New Year's holidays. The policy of *Ostpolitik*, championed by Willy Brandt, the mayor of West Berlin and eventual chancellor of the Federal Republic, would emerge out of diplomatic negotiations in which the two German regimes adjusted and began to openly acknowledge the endurance of the Berlin Wall.

Davis's journey to pursue a doctoral degree in philosophy at the Johann Wolfgang Goethe University in Frankfurt occurred in the midst of an